



“Slash-and-burn” farming in the rainforest of Brazil results in the eradication of native medicinal plants. Efforts are now under way to provide local farmers with alternative means of profiting from the land.

People began to realize that a serious cost could accompany the benefits of treatment with modern pharmaceutical drugs. This, and the factors described below, have brought about a sea change in public perceptions of the value of herbal medicine.

The Chinese Example

Herbal medicine experienced a major gain in fortune in 1949 in China, when Mao Zedong and the Communist Red Army gained control of the country.

Traditional Western medicine by that time was well established in China, but most of the population had little hope of access to modern hospitals, let alone to new drugs. Out of necessity, traditional Chinese medicine—essentially herbal medicine and acupuncture—once more began to be used alongside Western conventional medicine. The authorities aimed to provide the best of both worlds. Five teaching hospitals for traditional Chinese medicine (TCM) were established, where it was taught on a scientific basis. In addition, great efforts were made to improve the quality of plant medicines.

Contrary to the trend in conventional Western medicine that makes the patient ever more dependent upon the doctor and high-tech machinery, TCM, like other forms of complementary medicine, stresses the patient’s personal responsibility for his or her own cure, encouraging a holistic approach to treatment.

In the 1960s, China also established a system of “barefoot doctors.” After a period of basic medical instruction that blended herbal medicine, acupuncture, and Western practices, these practitioners were sent out to provide health care for the millions of rural Chinese too remote from cities to benefit from the facilities available there. The barefoot doctors in the late 1960s became a model for the World

Health Organization, which created a strategy of including traditional herbal practitioners in planning for the health care needs of developing countries.

Western Medicine & Herbal Practices

Further to the initiative by the World Health Organization, experience has shown that traditional (usually herbal) and Western medicine can indeed work well in tandem, although the relationship is often quite complex. J. M. Janzen’s *The Quest for Therapy in Lower Zaïre* (University of California Press, 1978) describes one such interaction in Africa:

“The people of Zaïre recognize the advantages of Western medicine and seek its surgery, drugs, and hospital care, but contrary to what might have been expected, native doctors, prophets, and traditional consultations among kinsmen do not disappear with the adoption of Western medicine. Rather a [working relationship] has developed in which different forms of therapy play complementary rather than competitive roles in the thoughts and lives of the people.”

The high cost of Western medical treatment is another factor that has encouraged people and governments to re-examine traditional healing. In China, Mexico, Cuba, Egypt, Ghana, India, and Mongolia, to give but a few examples, herbal medicines are being cultivated in greater quantities, and are being used to some degree by conventional as well as traditional practitioners.

Likewise, different types of treatment have evolved to meet the variety of needs within a population. India offers an extraordinary example of the kind of choices available in types of medical care. Alongside physicians trained in conventional Western medicine, there are medically trained Ayurvedic practitioners, traditional Ayurvedic practitioners, local healers, and homeopaths.

Changing Attitudes

Perhaps the most important factor behind the growing interest in complementary medicine is the poor state of health in Western societies. Conventional medicine has by and large brought serious infectious diseases under control, although there are worrying signs that infectious organisms are becoming resistant to antibiotic treatment, largely as a result of their indiscriminate use. Chronic illness, however, seems to be on the increase. Probably around 50 percent of people in Western countries daily take one or more conventional medicines—for conditions as diverse as high blood pressure, asthma, arthritis, and depression. Many Western countries such as the U.S. and France spend astronomical sums on health care, yet despite this massive investment, much of the population remains demonstrably unhealthy. Even the significant increase in life expectancy in developed countries is starting to go into reverse, perhaps a result of environmental pollutants and toxic accumulation within the body.